



coat of stiff,
sharp spines

European hedgehog

Erinaceus europaeus

With a coat of around 8,000 spines, the European hedgehog is one of the most recognizable—and most surprising—mammals. Earthworms, slugs, and snails feature in its diet, but its preferred food is insects, preferably ants and beetles. Stinging insects have little effect on it, and so it can even eat wasps and bees. A natural but variable resistance to venomous snakes allows it to eat adders as well. Hedgehogs spend daylight hours resting in shallow nests of leaves and twigs. At night they are highly active, covering up to 1 mile (2km) as they forage for food.

Handle with care

Mating is tricky. A male circles a female, which hisses and snorts, initially. However, if the female flattens her spines by relaxing a special muscle, the male will mate with her several times before leaving in search of other females. Each year female hedgehogs have one or two litters of two to seven hoglets, born with white spines encased in fluid-filled skin. Once the fluid dissipates, the spines are revealed and are replaced by a darker set two to three days later. The banded adult spines appear when they are two to three weeks old. When threatened, hedgehogs roll up into a tight ball. They also cover their spines with foamy saliva in a practice known as “self-anointing”—but the reason for this is uncertain.

- ↔ 8–11 in (20–28 cm)
- ⚖ 2 lb (1 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Insects, slugs, bird eggs
- 🏠 🌿 🌳 🌲



Europe



△ BUNDLED UP

Piles of leaves, fallen logs or twigs, or garden compost heaps are favorite hibernation locations for hedgehogs in winter.

◁ BLIND AT BIRTH

Hoglets are born blind and remain blind, like these two youngsters, for between 11 and 14 days, at which time they begin to open their eyes.